



PATH 16

Freelance, then productize

Charge the rate now. Build the product from the notes. Stop reinventing the job.

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Who this is for

You already do AI work for money and you are tired of quoting from scratch.

Time to first

You may already be here

Tools

First sale

A second similar job at a cleaner scope.

Cash window

Your current rate, then a named package, then a cheaper file

Leave this alone

Whatever you already invoice with, plus a growing checklist in one doc.

Random gigs forever. No notes. Quitting service before the notes exist.

What this actually is

The definition

You already do AI work for money. Someone asks what you charge. You shrug an hourly number, or you write a custom proposal that eats an evening, or you say yes to a job that does not look like the last one because variety feels like growth. This path is the decision to stop reinventing the job.

Take the last job you did well. Write the steps as a checklist the night you deliver. After three similar jobs, the package writes itself. That package is path 7 — a named service with a date and a price. The checklist is path 1 — a playbook a stranger can run without you.

Charge the rate now. Build the product from the notes. You do not pause income to "work on the business." You take similar work on purpose, you write it down, and you send a package name the next time someone asks what you charge.

What this is not

It is not a rebrand. It is not a new website. It is not quitting clients this month to "only sell digital products." It is not a 12-item menu of everything AI. It is not a course about productizing, taught before you have three similar invoices.

It is not undercharging because the draft arrived in twelve minutes. AI made it faster. That is what they are buying. Speed is the offer, not a reason to discount.

It is not collecting interesting gigs so your portfolio looks wide. Variety feels like growth. It is usually stalling.

Why this works now

Clients already want AI-assisted work: posts, listings, research briefs, internal SOPs, follow-up sequences. They do not want to learn the tools. They want a dated result. You already have invoices. Those invoices are a product hiding in messy naming.

The model got faster. Your judgment did not get cheaper. A job that used to take a day now takes three hours if you have a stack. That surplus is the package. If you keep billing hours, you donate the surplus. If you name the result and the days, you keep it.

Notes compound. One night-of-delivery doc becomes a one-pager, then a package, then a \$19–\$47 file. Skip the notes and you will still be quoting from scratch in December, only more tired.

Three anti-patterns

Anti-pattern one: random gigs forever, no notes. You are as good at quoting from scratch in month six as you were in month one. Recovery this week: open last three invoices, circle similar ones, write shared steps tonight.

Anti-pattern two: pause income to build the file. The file will be theoretical. You will have no proof and no cash. Recovery this week: take the next similar yes. Write it down. Outline the file after the third job, not instead of the second.

Anti-pattern three: a cafeteria of twelve services. If you have twelve, you have none. Recovery this week: pick the shape you would repeat. Name that one. Decline the rest or refer them.

The deal you keep

You keep charging. You keep writing the steps the night you deliver. They get a named result, a date, a price, one revision. You do not invent a unique process per client. Their facts are unique. The job is not.

The conversion is the point: freelance cash now, package next, file when the checklist is boring. Do not skip a layer because a thread said "productized" is more respectable.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

Fits if

This path fits if invoices already exist. You have done AI-assisted work for other people — posts, listings, research briefs, internal SOPs — and you can open a folder of paid jobs. You are tired of quoting from scratch. You may already be here.

It fits if you can tell the truth about which jobs were similar. Same kind of input, same kind of output, roughly the same number of days. A realtor listing pack and a dentist listing pack can be similar. A realtor listing pack and a custom chatbot are not.

It fits if you will write notes the night you deliver. The notes are the whole conversion. If you will not write them, you will still be shrugging rates in six months.

It also fits if you already run a productized package: raise when the waitlist appears, and spin the checklist into a file. You are on step 9.

Skip if

Skip it if you have never been paid. You cannot productize a fantasy. Skip it if you refuse to write notes. Skip it if you want to stop service this month and "only sell digital products." The honest road is three similar jobs, a named package, then a cheaper file of the job without you in the middle.

Skip it if every job you take is a new species on purpose. That is a custom-projects path. This path needs a repeating shape.

Skip it if you will not send a named price. If you need two hours and a slide deck to say \$750, you are still performing uniqueness.

The honest middle

You have four messy invoices, two of which look alike if you squint, and you still say "it depends" on calls. Circle the two. Make the next yes match them. You do not need a niche retreat. You need a sticky note with the job name and a paste for "what do you charge?"

If you have one invoice, that one is the circle. The first sale of this path is the second similar job.

Skills and time

Skills: notice similarity, write steps, say a number, take a deposit, decline off-shape work. You already know the job. You are missing the name and the notes habit.

Time this week: two hours to circle invoices, write shared steps, and name the package. Then twenty minutes the night of every delivery. Do not rebuild the website. Do not switch invoicing tools.

Two-minute self-test

Answer yes or no.

Can you open at least one paid invoice from AI-assisted work in the last 90 days?

Would you be willing to do that shape of job again next week?

Will you write notes the night you deliver, in the same doc, every time?

Can you say a package name and a price out loud without coughing?

Will you decline (or refer) a flattering gig that does not teach the package?

If 1 or 2 is no, get one paid job first, or use a productized-service path with a named offer this week. If 3, 4, or 5 is no, this path will stall in the shrug. Fix the habit, then name the package.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill-in-the-blank

When they ask your rate, name the package, not an hourly shrug.

The sentence: "[Named result] in [N days] for [price]. You get [files]. One revision. You provide [inputs]. Deposit [50%] holds the week."

"I can help with AI" is not an offer. If you need a paragraph of hedging, it is still a shrug.

Five sentences that work

12 posts and one landing draft in 7 days for \$600. You get files, not a login to my brain. You provide voice examples and facts on day one.

8 listing descriptions plus a Google Business week in 5 days for \$450. One revision. Deposit 50%.

Inbox to 15 follow-up emails in 10 days for \$750, built in your voice. Out: sitting in your Slack.

10 product descriptions and a collection-page draft in 6 days for \$550. You provide SKUs and photos. One revision window of 5 days.

Month-end close checklist run with you in 3 days for \$900. You provide the books. I return a dated packet you own.

What they get

A named result, a date, files they own, a short walkthrough, one revision window. They get your judgment on their facts. They get speed they cannot buy from a blank chat window.

What they do not get

Unlimited rounds. Extra channels. A chatbot. A brand deck. You on Slack all week. Strategy as a bonus. Raw model output. A custom species of job dressed up as the package.

The service package is you in the middle. The product version is the job without you, priced lower. They do not have to buy the file. You do not refuse paid work while you "wait to productize."

Packaging

You do not invent this on a branding retreat. You circle the similar invoices, write the shared steps, and name what you already delivered. One page: in, out, timeline, price, inputs, revision rule, deposit. Ugly is fine.

Clock starts when inputs arrive, not when they said yes. Deposit before you open the chat. 50% to start. Delivery in a folder they own.

The file comes later: \$19–\$47, same steps, no you in the middle. Mention it after delivery and to people who cannot afford the package. Do not hide the package to force the file.

What done looks like

Definition

Done for the first 72 hours: last three invoices open, similar ones circled, shared steps written, package named, and that name sitting in a note you will paste the next time someone asks what you charge.

Done for the first sale of this path: a second similar job at a cleaner scope. Not a bigger job. A cleaner one. Same shape as the last, written scope, deposit, one revision, a date. If you still said "sure, I can also do the chatbot and the brand voice and the ads," you smiled. You did not productize.

A job is done when the night-of-delivery notes exist in the same doc you always use: steps, prompts you reused, what they failed to provide, how long it actually took, what you will refuse next time.

A package is done when you can send it without opening a blank proposal. Name, deliverable, timeline, price, inputs, revision rule. One page. The product version is later. This path's finish line is the named package and the habit of notes.

Fairness test

Could a past client read the one-pager and know exactly what they get, when, and what they must provide? If they would still ask "so what do you actually do," it is not done.

Would you take a second job at this scope without dreading it? If the scope still includes "and whatever else comes up," you have not productized. You have renamed the shrug.

Technical done

One running notes doc, dated entries.

Prompt stack under the steps where you used them.

One-pager in a shareable doc.

Deposit link that matches the invoice tool you already use.

Paste on your phone for "what do you charge?"

A written out-list: the extras you will not do inside this price.

Not-done-yet list

A new website. Not done-yet. Past clients will read a Google doc.

A CRM, a scheduler, a course platform. Not done-yet.

Twelve packages. Not done-yet. One until the paste is automatic.

The \$27 file before the second similar job. Not done-yet. The file will be a guess.

Hourly with a smile because they asked. Not done. That is the old job.

Working before the deposit. Not done. The "quick call" became the job.

Pricing and the cash window

Ranges

The cash window is your current rate, then a package. You do not cut your rate to "make it productized." You stop pretending every job is unique.

If you already charge \$75 an hour, and a job eats 8 hours including the smiling and the revisions, the package is not \$200 because AI drafted fast. The package is \$600–\$900 with a date, or whatever math matches the last invoices plus a little for the cleaner scope. Speed is what they buy. You keep the surplus.

First packages in this suite's service path often live at \$300–\$1,500. A 3-day listing pack can be \$400. A 10-day follow-up system can be \$900. A 14-day content-plus-page can be \$1,200. Write what is in and what is out so the number has a spine. Deposit before you open the chat. 50% to start.

If you have been undercharging, do not leap to \$5,000 because a thread told you to. Average the last three similar invoices. Round up to a number you can say without coughing. That is v1.

When the checklist is boring because you have run it three times, price the file at \$19–\$47. Cheaper than hiring you. That is the point. It does not replace the \$600 until you want it to.

When to raise

Raise when a waitlist appears — meaning someone has to wait a week or you are turning people away. Add 15–30%. Keep the scope. Do not add more deliverables to justify the raise.

Raise also when the notes show the job is heavier than the old invoices implied. If every job leaks six extra hours of Slack, either the out-list is weak or the price is wrong. Fix the out-list first. Then raise.

Refunds in one sentence

Refund the deposit only if you have not opened their inputs; after work starts, finish or keep the deposit and hand over whatever is already in their folder.

Never-charge

Do not charge a "discovery fee" that becomes the whole job for free. Do not charge \$49 for a package that eats two days — that is a file price on a service calendar. Do not charge extra mid-job because you forgot to write the out-list. Do not discount because AI was fast. Do not work the second half on a promise.

Worked dollars

Drew's second similar job: \$750, 50% deposit \$375 before chat, delivered in 6 days, notes that night. After three jobs, raise to \$900 because a fourth had to wait a week. File at \$27. Two file sales in a month while inside a paid week: \$54 extra, not a reason to kill the \$900 week.

Your v1: average of last similar invoices, rounded up. Say it once on a call so you do not fold.

The first 72 hours

You are not building a new brand. You are opening invoices.

Day 1 morning: circle

Open the last three invoices, or the last five if three is too thin. Circle the similar ones. Similar = same kind of input, same kind of output, same-ish days. If none are similar, circle the one you would be willing to do again, and treat the next yes as the second data point. Write the names of the jobs on a sticky: "listing packs," not "misc AI help."

Do not open a new Notion palace. One doc. Title it with the job name.

Day 1 afternoon: shared steps

From the circled jobs, write the shared steps in that doc. Intake, inputs you needed, the AI draft pass, the edit pass, the delivery folder, the walkthrough, the revision window. Put the prompts you reused under the step where you used them. This doc is the company.

List what they failed to provide. That list becomes intake. List what they talked you into. That list becomes "out."

Day 1 night: hours and a number

Write how long each circled job actually took, including smiling and revisions. Average it. Multiply by your real hourly if you must, then round up to a package number you can say. Put the number on the sticky next to the job name. Sleep on it. Do not discount it overnight.

Day 2: name and one-pager

Name the package like a result: "7-day listing pack." Write what's in, what's not, timeline, price (from the invoices, rounded up), what they must provide, one revision, 50% deposit. The one-pager is a Google doc. Ugly. Fine.

Put the name in a note on your phone. Practice saying it out loud once so you do not fold on a call.

Make sure the deposit link you already use still works. Do not switch billing tools this week.

Day 3: paste and two sends

The next time someone asks "what do you charge?" you send the package, not an hourly shrug. If nobody is asking this week, send the one-pager to two past clients who already liked the work. Subject: "This job has a name now." One paragraph. Link to the one-pager. No apology for the old rate.

By hour 72: last invoices open, similar ones circled, shared steps in one doc, package named, one page, paste ready for the next "what do you charge?"

The path, step by step

Step 1. Open the last three invoices and circle the similar ones

If you cannot find similarity, you have been collecting gigs. The next yes should look like the best of those jobs, not a new species. Write the job name on a sticky. If you only have one invoice, circle that one and aim the next yes at the same shape.

Step 2. Write the steps the night you deliver

Same day, while the mess is still in your head. Tomorrow you will only remember the win. The product lives in the missing inputs, the prompt that worked, the extra round they talked you into. If you skip this night, you skipped the path. The invoice is the job. The notes are the company.

Step 3. Notes in the same doc after every job

One running file. Dated entries. Do not start a new Notion palace per client. Date, client type, what they provided, what they skipped, steps you actually ran, prompts you reused, hours start to finish, what you will refuse next time, one line you could sell as a file.

Step 4. Prompts you reused go in a stack

If you typed it twice, it belongs in a block you can paste. That stack becomes part of the package and, later, part of a file. Leave them in chat history and you will rewrite them badly under deadline.

Step 5. Name the package

Result, days, price. Stop the hourly shrug. Practice saying it out loud once so you do not fold on a call. "8 listings and one page draft in 7 days for \$750" is a name. "AI content help" is a weather report.

Step 6. Write what's in, what's out, the date, the deposit

One revision is enough. Unlimited revisions is how packages die. They must provide voice, examples, and access on day one or the clock does not start. Deposit 50% before you open the chat. Put this on one page you can reuse twenty times.

Step 7. Send that name the next time someone asks what you charge

Even if the one-pager is ugly. A named package is cleaner than a charming email. If they are not a fit for this shape, say so and point them at the file or a no. Do not write a custom proposal "just this once." Just this once is how the shrug returns.

Step 8. Stop saying yes to work that does not teach the product

A flattering weird gig will pay once and steal the notes week. Refer it or decline. If you take one on purpose, call it tuition, cap the hours, and do not let it rename the package.

Step 9. After three similar jobs, the package writes itself

You are not guessing scope. You have dates and hours. Tighten the one-pager. That package is path 7. The checklist is path 1. Stop custom proposals for this shape of work.

Step 10. Raise the package price when the waitlist appears

Waitlist means delay or a no because you are full. Add 15–30%, keep the scope. Do not add more deliverables to justify the raise. Politeness is how packages get fat and unprofitable.

Step 11. Make the product version: the job without you in the middle

Price it lower. Let it sell while you sleep. Do this after the checklist is boring, not instead of the next paid job. The file is the steps, prompts, examples, and definition of done. It is not a memoir

about your clients.

Step 12. Do not undercharge because AI made it fast

They bought speed and judgment. If a job that used to take a day now takes three hours, you did not become cheaper. You became a better package. Keep the price. Shrink the timeline if you want, on purpose, as part of the offer.

Step 13. Deposit before the chat, clock on inputs

Working before the deposit trains them that the "quick call" is the job. Starting before inputs arrive trains you to invent their facts. Both kill the checklist because the job never has a clean start.

Step 14. Keep taking packages until you choose not to

The file does not require you to quit service. Two \$27 sales are not a reason to decline a \$900 week. Choose later, on purpose, when the file is actually carrying weight.

A worked example: Drew names the package

Drew has been "doing AI stuff" for six months. Invoices: \$400 to rewrite a dentist's Google posts, \$650 to draft listing copy for a realtor friend, \$300 to "just help with ChatGPT" for a cousin's bakery, \$800 for another realtor's listings plus a landing page. Drew quotes from scratch every time.

Tuesday night, the circle

Drew circles the two realtor jobs and, after a pause, the dentist posts. Same shape: messy facts in, a week of public-facing copy out. The bakery cousin is not circled. Sticky note: "do not take cousin work."

Shared steps go in one doc that night: intake, folder of inputs, draft pass, human edit, delivery in a Google doc they own, 15-minute walkthrough, one revision window of 5 days. Reused prompts get pasted under the draft step. Hours: the \$650 job was really 11 hours with extras. The \$800 job

was 9 hours with a cleaner intake. Drew averages toward 10, multiplies by a \$75 habit, and rounds to \$750 instead of \$400 because speed is the offer.

Wednesday, the name

Drew names it: 8 listings and one page draft in 7 days for \$750. Out: ads, chatbots, unlimited rounds. Deposit 50%. The one-pager is a Google doc. Ugly. Fine. Paste goes on the phone.

Thursday, the shrug test

An acquaintance asks what Drew would charge "to help with AI." Drew pastes the package name instead of "I usually do \$75 an hour." The acquaintance is not a realtor. Drew says this package is for listings and a page. Two hours saved. No custom proposal.

Week 2, first sale of the path

The next realtor who asks gets the same paste. They say yes. Deposit \$375 lands before the chat. Drew does not open Slack until the MLS notes and three example listings arrive. Delivers in 6 days, writes the notes that night (they always forget parking details; add that to intake). That is the first sale of this path: a second similar job at a cleaner scope.

Mistake: Drew almost added "a week of Instagram" as a smile. Caught it because the out-list was on the one-pager. Recovery: "That's out of this package. I can point you at the playbook when it exists, or we keep the listings and the page."

After the third listing-pack job

Drew raises to \$900 when a fourth has to wait a week. The checklist is boring enough to become a \$27 playbook. The file sells twice in a month while Drew is inside a paid week: \$54. The hourly shrug is gone. The cousin still wants "a little help." Drew sends the playbook link.

What Drew refused: a new website, a 12-service menu, pausing paid weeks to design a cover, undercharging because Claude drafted in twelve minutes, and the bakery-shaped work that would have taught nothing.

Copy you can paste

Swap the result, the days, and the price. Keep the spine.

Public post

I do not bill a pile of hours for this anymore. It is a named package: [result] in [N] days for [price]. You get [files], one revision, and a short walkthrough. You provide [inputs] on day one. Deposit holds the week. One-pager: [link].

DM, when they ask what you charge

I can do [named result] in [N] days for [price]. Files you own, one revision, walkthrough. You send [inputs] before I start. 50% deposit holds the seat. Here is the one-pager. If you need something else, I probably will not take it — I can point you at the [file] if it exists.

Page hero

[Result] in [N] days. You get files, not a login to my brain. \$[price]. One revision. Deposit 50%.

Checkout / deposit line

50% now holds the week. Clock starts when [inputs] arrive. Balance before I send the folder. One revision window of 5 days after delivery. No Slack retainer inside this price.

Email 1 — to a past client

You already paid me for [old job]. That work has a name now: [result] in [N] days for [price]. Same shape, cleaner scope, one revision. If you need it again, the one-pager is here. If not, no need to reply.

Email 2 — inputs are late

The week is held by the deposit, but the clock has not started. I need [list] before I open the draft. If that is not coming this week, we pick a new start date or I refund the unused deposit.

Email 3 — delivery

Folder is yours: [link]. Walkthrough is [15 minutes, date]. One revision round, grouped notes, inside 5 days. After that the job is closed. Notes I will use next time are on me, not on you.

Refund

I have not opened your inputs, so the deposit is back. If you want this package later, same one-pager. If the shape changed, I probably cannot take it.

Scope block for the one-pager

In: [deliverables]. Out: [the usual extras — extra rounds, extra channels, strategy decks, sitting in their Slack]. Timeline: start when inputs arrive, end on date. Price: [amount]. Deposit: 50% before I open the work. Revisions: one round within 5 days of delivery.

Notes template, the night you deliver

Date. Client type. What they provided / what they skipped. Steps I actually ran. Prompts I reused. Hours start to finish. What I will refuse next time. One line I could sell as a file.

Decline that teaches the product

This sounds like a custom build, and I am not taking those. If you want [the named package], I have a seat in [week]. If you want to run it without me, the [playbook / stack] is [price] and it is the same steps.

Raise, when they wait

The package is [new price] starting [date]. Same scope. I am booking [N] weeks out. Deposit still holds the slot.

Week-by-week

Assume you have a job and evenings. This is four weeks to a second similar job and a paste, not a new brand.

Week 1, daily

Day 1: open last three to five invoices. Circle similar ones. Sticky with the job name.

Day 2: write shared steps in one doc. Paste reused prompts under the step. List missing inputs and extras you regretted.

Day 3: name the package (result, days, price). Draft the one-pager: in, out, deposit, one revision.

Day 4: put the paste on your phone. Practice saying the price out loud. Test the deposit link you already use.

Day 5: send the one-pager to two past clients. Do not rebuild the website.

Day 6–7: if someone asks what you charge, send the package. If not, do not invent a random gig so you feel busy. Clean the notes doc.

Week 2, daily

Day 8–9: next conversation uses the paste. Take a deposit before the chat. Clock starts when inputs arrive.

Day 10–12: run the job if you have one. Human pass on every deliverable. They never see raw model output.

Day 13: deliver in a folder they own. Walkthrough. One revision window with a date.

Day 14: notes in the same doc the night you deliver. Prompts you reused go in the stack. That night is non-negotiable.

Week 3

Tighten what's in and what's out from the last job's leaks. If you got burned by extra rounds, the one-revision line gets bolder, not politer. Send two more past-client notes if the calendar is empty. No to work that does not teach the package.

Week 4

If you have two similar jobs, you have the first sale of this path. If you have three, stop custom proposals for this shape. Sketch the product version from the checklist — but do not disappear from paid weeks to design a cover. If a waitlist appeared, raise 15–30% and keep the scope.

Weeks 5–8

Every week you deliver anything: notes that night. When the checklist is boring, ship the cheaper file. Mention it after delivery and to people who cannot afford the package. Keep taking packages until you choose not to.

Weeks 9–12

One package until the paste is automatic. A second package is how you end up quoting from scratch again. Review hours per package vs price. If the surplus disappeared, tighten scope or raise. Do not add three new deliverables so you feel polite.

Quality bar

They never see the raw model output. That is the floor. AI drafts. You edit. Quality is your name, not the model's.

Below-bar

Hourly shrug or a custom proposal that ate an evening.

Work started before deposit or before inputs.

They received unedited model text.

Unlimited rounds, or "quick tweaks" with no date.

Delivery in your Google account, not a folder they own.

No notes the night of delivery.

Second job is bigger and fuzzier than the first.

You said yes to a chatbot "while you're in there."

Above-bar

Written scope before work. Deposit before chat.

Inputs listed. Clock starts when they arrive.

Human pass on every deliverable. Facts checked. Voice matches their examples, not "an AI that heard of their industry."

Delivery in a folder they own. A 15-minute walkthrough. One revision window with a date.

Notes the night you deliver, in the same doc.

Similarity is real, not branded. You can say in one sentence what matches across the circled jobs.

The package name is a result plus a date plus a price.

You declined at least one job that would have felt like growth and would have taught nothing.

Five tests

Test 1, the paste. Can you send the package in under five minutes from "what do you charge?" If this is still two hours, you do not have a package. You have a ritual.

Test 2, the stranger one-pager. Could a tired client know in, out, date, price, inputs, revision without a call? If not, rewrite tonight.

Test 3, cleaner scope. Does the second similar job have fewer side quests than the first? If it is bigger and fuzzier, you went the wrong direction.

Test 4, the night notes. Binary. If you skipped, you skipped the company. Recovery this week: write last job's notes from memory tonight, then never skip again.

Test 5, the no. Did you decline off-shape work this month? If this is zero, you are still collecting gigs. Recovery: write one decline this week using the script.

Cleaner scope means fewer extra rounds and fewer "while you're in there." That is the quality of the path, not a prettier logo.

What to measure

Week 1

Invoices opened and similar ones circled (count).

Shared steps written (binary).

Package named with a number (binary).

Paste sitting on the phone (binary).

One-pagers sent to past clients (target 2).

Day 30

Similar jobs in a row. Two is the first-sale line.

Proposal time. Minutes from "what do you charge" to a sent package. If this is still two hours, you do not have a package.

Hours per package vs price. Know the number.

Revision count. More than one as a habit means your definition of done is soft or your intake is weak.

Notes completed the night of delivery (binary, every job).

Nos to off-shape work (if zero, you are still collecting gigs).

Day 90

Three similar jobs. Package is real. Custom proposals for this shape should be zero.

Waitlist days. When people wait, raise.

Product-version shipped or outlined from a boring checklist.

Product-version sales, separate from package revenue. Do not kill a \$900 week because a \$27 file feels more "scalable" on a slide.

Surplus still exists (price minus hours times your floor rate).

Ignore

Do not measure how many different industries you have touched. That is a stalling trophy. Do not measure proposal win rate on custom work you should not have bid. Do not measure

"personal brand" posts this week.

One-line spreadsheet

Date | job shape | price | deposit date | hours | revisions | notes same night (Y/N) | off-shape nos | waitlist days | file sales | one sentence

One row per job. If you need a CRM to see the streak, you are avoiding the doc.

Objections you will hear — including from yourself

"Every client is unique."

Their business is unique. The job is not. Eight listings and a page is eight listings and a page. Unique belongs in their facts, not in your process. Reply: "Your facts are yours. The steps are the package. That's how it stays on time."

"I will productize after I quit clients."

You will have no notes, no proof, and no cash. Charge now. Notes tonight. File later. Reply to yourself: "The notes are the company. Quitting first is a fantasy with a cover."

"AI made it fast, so I should charge less."

They are buying the speed. Keep the price. Offer a shorter timeline if you want the speed visible. Reply: "The result is dated and edited. The speed is why you hire me. The number stays."

"A package will make me miss interesting work."

It will. That is the trade. Interesting work that never repeats is a class you pay for with your calendar. Take one on purpose once a quarter if you must. Reply: "I take one weird job a quarter as tuition. This week is the package."

"I need a new website first."

You need a one-pager and a paste. Reply: "The Google doc is the page until strangers I do not know are buying."

"What if they want hourly?"

You can say no. If a trusted client insists, cap the hours and still write the steps. Do not live there. Reply: "I do not bill a pile of hours for this. It's [package]. If hourly is required, I am not the person."

"I only have one invoice."

Circle that one. Aim the next yes at the same shape. The first sale is the second similar job. Reply to yourself: "One is a start. The next yes matches it."

"They asked me to add just one more thing."

That is how packages die. Reply: "That's out of this package. We can date a separate week at [price], or we keep this scope."

"I am scared to lose them if I name a real number."

A client who only exists when the scope is fog is not a client you can productize around. Reply: "The number is [price]. Deposit holds the week. If that is not a fit, I will not force it."

"Should I productize two jobs at once?"

Later. One package until the paste is automatic and the notes are boring. Reply to yourself: "Two packages is the shrug in a trench coat."

What feeds this path

Upstream — what must exist first

The last jobs. Invoices, emails, folders, Slack threads. Mine them before you invent a niche. If you have never been paid, this is not your first path. Get one paid result, then come back.

The night-of-delivery doc. Every entry feeds the one-pager and, later, the file. Skip a night and the feed dries up.

People who already paid you. They are the easiest second similar job. "If you need this again, it has a name now."

Downstream — what this feeds

Path 7, the named package, once three similar jobs exist. Path 1, the playbook, once the checklist is boring. Path 2 or 3 if the reused prompts are the product. Path 15 if operators start asking how you run the week.

The questions inside the job. "Can you also..." is how you learn what to put in "what's out." Intake gets sharper. The package gets kinder to you.

Prompts you reused. They are a stack waiting to happen. Do not leave them in chat history.

What does not feed it

Job boards that want a new species every time. "Happy to help with anything AI." Those feeds train the shrug. When a week has no freelance work, the feed is still the doc. Clean it. Send two past clients the one-pager. Do not fill the week with a random gig so you feel busy.

A niche-picking Twitter poll. A new logo. A second service "so I have a funnel." One shape. Repeat it.

Mistakes

1. Random gigs forever. No notes

You will be as good at quoting from scratch in December as you were in March, only more tired. The notes are the path. Recovery this week: open last three invoices, start the running doc tonight, write the last job from memory.

2. Custom work that never repeats

It feels like a portfolio. It is a stall. If it does not teach the package, it is a no. Recovery this week: decline or refer one off-shape ask. Use the decline script.

3. Undercharging because AI made it fast

Speed is the product. Keep the rate. Tighten the days if you want. Put the days on the package. Recovery this week: rewrite the one-pager at last-invoice-average rounded up. Send that number next.

4. Working before the deposit

The "quick call" becomes the job. Recovery this week: deposit link in the paste. Do not open the work folder until it lands.

5. Unlimited revisions

Then there is no definition of done, and the checklist cannot be written because the job never ends. Recovery this week: one round, grouped notes, 5-day window, on the one-pager in bold.

6. Building the file instead of taking the second similar job

The file will be theoretical. Take the job. Write it down. Then productize. Recovery this week: pause the cover design. Send two past clients the package.

7. A menu of 12 services

If you have twelve, you have none. One package. Not a cafeteria. Recovery this week: pick one shape. Hide the rest. Name it.

8. Clock started before inputs arrived

You invent their facts, then you revise forever. Recovery this week: write "clock starts when [inputs] arrive" on the one-pager. Email anyone in flight whose inputs are missing.

9. Switching tools instead of writing steps

New CRM, new scheduler, new invoicing app. The bottleneck is the notes. Recovery this week: keep the old invoice tool. Write the steps.

10. Adding deliverables when you raise

You feel polite. You destroy the surplus. Recovery this week: raise 15–30% or do not raise. Scope stays. Say that out loud.

11. Letting a cousin job rename the business

One bakery, one chatbot, one "just help me understand AI." Recovery this week: sticky note of what you will not take. Send the file link instead.

12. Skipping notes because the job went fine

Fine jobs still have steps. Recovery this week: twenty minutes tonight. Date the entry. Paste the prompts.

Tools

Exact stack

Whatever you already invoice with. Stripe, HoneyBook, an invoice PDF, Venmo with a paper trail. Do not switch billing tools this week.

A growing checklist in one doc. Google Doc, Notion, a notes app. One. Dated. Ugly.

A one-page agreement. Scope, date, price, deposit, one revision, what they provide. You can reuse this 20 times.

A deposit link. Same as the invoice tool. 50% before the chat.

The prompt stack you actually reused, sitting under the step where it belongs.

A phone note with the paste for "what do you charge?"

Setup order

Open invoices. Circle similar.

Create the one running doc. Write shared steps.

Paste reused prompts under steps.

Write the one-pager.

Confirm the deposit link works (send \$1 to yourself if you must).

Put the paste on the phone.

Then send. Not a new website first.

What not to buy

You do not need a new CRM to productize. You do not need a scheduler until people are actually booking. You do not need a course platform to turn the checklist into a \$27 file — a PDF and a payment link will do when the time comes. You do not need a proposal tool that writes five pages of fog. You do not need a brand kit.

The \$0 path

Invoice PDF or a payment link you already have. Google Doc for notes and the one-pager. Phone notes for the paste. Email for sending. A folder they own (Google Drive or email attachments). This is enough for the second similar job. Buy Stan or Stripe later if you do not already have them. The bottleneck is not software. It is writing the steps the night you deliver and sending a name instead of a shrug.

Checklist

This week

Last three invoices open. Similar ones circled.

Job name on a sticky (not "misc AI help").

Shared steps in one doc.

Reused prompts pasted under the step.

Package named: result, days, price.

What's in / what's out / deposit / one revision.

One-pager exists and is shareable.

Paste saved for "what do you charge?"

Deposit link tested.

Two past clients sent the one-pager.

Price said out loud once.

Every job

Deposit before the chat.

Clock starts when inputs arrive.

They never see raw model output.

Facts checked. Voice matches their examples.

Deliver in a folder they own.

Walkthrough booked.

One revision window with a date.

Notes in the same doc the night you deliver.

Reused prompts copied into the stack.

One line written that could become a file.

After three similar jobs

Stop custom proposals for this shape.

No to work that does not teach the product.

Raise when people wait (15–30%, same scope).

Outline the cheaper file from the boring checklist.

Ship the file without quitting the paid package.

Spreadsheet row per job: price, hours, revisions, notes Y/N.

FAQ

I only have messy one-off jobs. Can I still start?

Yes. Circle the one you would repeat. Make the next yes match it. The first sale of this path is the second similar job, not a perfect history. Default: circle one this week, aim the next ask at it.

What if I am not sure I want to keep doing service?

Keep doing it long enough to write the notes. Three similar jobs. Then the file can carry more of the weight. Quitting before the notes exist leaves you with neither cash nor a product. Default: three jobs, then decide.

How is this different from the productized service path?

That path assumes you can name the package this week and sell it. This path is for people already in the messy middle of freelance. You convert what you have. The destination — a named package — is the same room. Default: use this path if invoices exist and names do not.

Should I put the package on a fancy page?

A one-pager is enough until strangers you do not know are buying. Past clients will read a Google doc. Do not stall on Webflow. Default: Google doc this week.

How many revisions is one?

One round of grouped notes inside a dated window, usually 5 days. Not a drip of "quick tweaks" for a month. Put that in the one-pager. Default: one round, 5 days, grouped.

What goes in the product version vs the package?

The product version is the steps, prompts, examples, and definition of done — the job without you. The package is you running those steps on their mess, with judgment and a date. Default: package first, file after the checklist is boring.

The client wants hourly and I am scared to lose them.

Name the package once. If they still want hourly, cap the hours and the extras, or let them go. A client who only exists when the scope is fog is not a client you can productize around. Default: name it once, then no.

When do I raise the price?

When someone waits, or when you are full, or when the notes show the job is heavier than the old invoices implied. Add 15–30%. Do not add three new deliverables so you feel polite. Default: raise at the first wait.

Can I productize more than one job?

Later. One package until the paste is automatic and the notes are boring. A second package is how you end up quoting from scratch again. Default: one.

AI did 80% of the draft. Is charging \$750 honest?

If you edited, checked facts, matched voice, owned the result, and saved them a week in the blank window, yes. You are not selling keystrokes. You are selling a dated result they can use. If you are shipping unedited model text, fix the quality bar before you worry about the number. Default: edit or do not send.

What if nobody asks this week?

Send the one-pager to two past clients. Do not take a random gig to feel busy. Default: two notes, then wait.

Do I need a contract lawyer?

A one-page scope with deposit, date, out-list, and revision window is enough for this price band. If a client wants a 20-page MSA, that is a different job. Default: one page you reuse.

Should I hire a VA to run the package?

Not until the checklist is boring and you can still stand the quality bar. Default: you run it through job three.

What if inputs never arrive?

Deposit holds or refunds per your sentence. Clock never started. Do not chase forever. Default: one reminder, then a new date or a refund of unused deposit.

Can the file replace me this quarter?

Sometimes. Not on purpose in week one. Default: sell the file beside the package, not instead of the next \$750 week.

How long should a package take me?

Whatever the last three similar jobs actually took, minus the extras you now refuse, plus a human edit. Write the number. If it is 14 hours at \$750, you have a \$50-ish hour after smiling. Raise or tighten. Default: know the hours before you brag about leverage.